

Dear Jen,

Yesterday was a relatively easy day. The TOC was slow and quiet for most of the afternoon and any activity seemed to come in spurts. We had a visit from a General which was probably the highlight of the day for my commanders. I'm sure they took great pride in relaying our daily operations and activities. I was, thankfully, still asleep during this visit. I don't care for the pomp and circumstance which serves only to disrupt my routine in the office. Whenever we receive important people, everything has to stop as we dress up the relatively simple office space and try to make everything look as neat and tidy as possible. Yes, I am definitely thankful that the General visited during Sproesser's shift and not mine.

Today, however, I learned that Lt. Sproesser will be leaving the TOC. It is great for him; he will be joining getting a platoon, and finally inherit the job that we went to OCS to get. Yet, I am still upset by this. We have worked together in the TOC since we arrived in Kuwait, and it has been like our shared little misery. We learned the job together and have shared the burden of being brand new lieutenants in the TOC. It was our little circle, he worked then I worked, and now it is broken. I can only imagine how exciting it would be to get out of here and out into the city, to actually interact with the local population rather than to sit here and monitor the action through the radio. I wish I was going—but there is no chance of that happening. For some reason this has made me more depressed than usual. Well, good for him.

Otherwise things are very slow now. The initial rush and panic caused by moving the entire battalion has settled, and there is once again little for us to do. I spend most of my shift waiting for the time to pass, and ironically, the minute hand seems to move much slower when you watch it. It seems that even the looting and unrest in our sector seems to be diminishing. Instead of coordinating for EPW and Criminal transports last night, I simply waited out my time. At the beginning of the evening, Captain Hamilton, Lt. Collins and I spent a good half an hour joking about the absurd reports we would get to send up that night as our Traffic Control Points stopped assorted criminals, but they never came. The only report we received was around 1 am. Ace had stopped two men in a stolen vehicle with no weapons. They easily secured them and turned them over to local authorities that are now beginning to function again. It was an anti-climax.

I do track the occasional spot report and situation updates, and I diligently place the pins where they are supposed to go so that our map stays up to date with the current activity. I answer radio checks and take notes during the Brigade Commander's Conference Call. When the XO and the Commander finally go to bed, I play Worms against Specialist Bellinger and Lt. Collins. I think that we are getting way too good at such a simple little game that was probably not meant to be played as much as we play it.

Today has passed with little incident. I have been feeling somewhat down with Sproesser finally escaping the TOC and the thought of an endless, indefinite number of days left in

country. I wish now, I had stayed Field Artillery. At least this way I would be out doing Civil Affairs work instead of being stuck in here all of the time. I am probably rambling on at this point, but it is hard to sum up how I feel. It is not very difficult work, but intensely boring, and I had hoped to be in a leadership role. I want to be involved in the actions rather than simply recording them from far away. I have sent you letters on this subject before so I will drop it.

Charlie-Rock arrived here today, as did A/1-41 IN (Avalanche). Both are from Ft. Riley so now you shouldn't be the only lonely housewife around anymore. I hope that their arrival, and the arrival of the 1st Armor Division, is a step towards our being relieved, but I fear that Colonel Gold will try to keep us here for the duration of his tour in Iraq. No one seems to know anything. This is probably why the FRG can't seem to figure out what is going on. How could they know anything, if we don't know anything either. That sucks, let me tell you. I wonder if it would be easier if we had deployed as part of a peace keeping operation and had been told that we would have to be over here for six, seven, or eight months before we left. It is an interesting trade off isn't it? On the one hand we would know when we would be coming home, but there would be no hope of returning any sooner. This way, we have no idea, but we could leave at any time. Hmmm. I think, if I had to guess from current conversation around here, that Colonel Gold may try to make us stay. The reason I think so is because it was mentioned today by Captain Nutt that Colonel Gold will try to let people go home if they are having babies etc... This makes me think that he will try to keep the Battalion here longer. Speculation, speculation, speculation.

As for now, I will go back to my duty as the TOC Lieutenant and try to keep abreast of any rumor surrounding our redeployment. I hope that everything is going well back at home...and who did the Redskins draft? I need to get back to the States so that I can figure out if the Redskins will win the Superbowl next year. I'm sure Steve has some theories as far as that goes. What do you think? I wish I had more to tell you, but there are no captivating stories that I can conjure up at this point.

Take care and stay safe. I love both you and Mason very much—I wish I could hide as a stowaway on Cobra Companies flight home, but unfortunately that will not be possible. Today is May 11 which means that I will get to talk to you in just 48 hours. How cool is that.

Love,

Christian